

pro-Western General Phoumi Nosavan's forces as they advanced on Vientiane, which the neutralists had seized in a coup d'état led by Captain Kong Le.

Phoumi's men occupied Vientiane, causing Kong Le to enter into a new alliance. In early 1961, the coalition of Kong Le's neutralists, Pathet Lao, and North Vietnamese (NVA) troops fought Phoumi and the Special Forces at the Plain of Jars, a strategically critical area of grassy hills. In subsequent fighting, the Special Forces suffered their first casualties. Sergeant First Class John Bischoff and Sergeant Gerald Biber, members of Captain Walter Moon's four-man-strong Field Tracking Team, were killed in action on April 22. Moon himself was taken prisoner—as was Sergeant Orville Ballenger a week later.

Kennedy seeks neutrality

Deciding what to do about Laos was the first foreign policy dilemma that President Kennedy would face. Eisenhower had advised the new president that the situation in Laos was so grave that it might be necessary to deploy ground forces. Laos, he said, was the key to all of Southeast Asia. If it fell to communism, then South Vietnam, Cambodia, Burma, and Thailand would follow.

However, Kennedy did not send US ground troops into action. In April, he concluded that a negotiated settlement was the best he could hope for and agreed to participate in a peace conference. More than a year of talks followed. In July 1962, an agreement was finally made to establish a neutral and independent Laos.



Passing the torch

Kennedy discusses matters of state with Eisenhower on January 19, 1961, the day before his inauguration. This was an informal meeting to discuss continuing problems, especially the situation in Indochina.

Operation Momentum